



**MIDDLESEX Community College**

**Tools and Technologies for Tech Writers 2026**

**Week 11**

**Sample Bookmap**

# Middlesex Community College 2026

This document was prepared as an assignment for the Middlesex Community College Tools and Technologies for Technical Writers class, Winter semester 2026.

Prepared by Ben Fortier.

The name is defined by the value of the author key defined in your bookmap. I set them up to be your name.

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# My First Topic

This is a sample topic. It is in your homework folder (Ben) and is not shared.

This is a paragraph.

# Example Topic

The topic is the default, unspecialised topic type of DITA.

The `<topic>` is the basic building block of DITA. All other topic types are derived/specialized from the topic.

In general, when authoring, avoid using `<topic>` type topics because they carry no special meaning. However, they do serve some very important purposes:

- Provide the basic topic type to specialize from.

If you choose to create your own topic types, you can start with a topic and go from there.

- Provide a default for conversion work.

When converting to DITA, you don't always do all the work you should do to identify topic types. You can convert everything to topics and then sort them out later.

- Great for what I call "container topics"

Most DITA generation tools allow for auto-generated links, especially child links. To structure your content, you can create a topic with nothing but a title. The child links (and optional short descriptions) can be included automatically.

## Topic Building Blocks

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Brief rundown of the elements you can use in `<topic>` type topics.

### Structure Blocks

These are the elements that make up a topic.

|                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>topic</b>     | The defining container                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>title</b>     | All topics need a title. Note that there is only one <code>&lt;title&gt;</code> element. All things that can use a title use this same element, whether that is a topic, section, figure, table, etc.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>shortdesc</b> | <p>The short description for the topic. This is the first sentence of the topic. This element can be picked up in search results or when generating links.</p> <p>Alternatively, you can use an <code>&lt;abstract&gt;</code>. The <code>&lt;abstract&gt;</code> allows for more content than a <code>&lt;shortdesc&gt;</code>, but it is not extracted and reused the same way. However, you can place multiple <code>&lt;shortdesc&gt;</code> inside an <code>&lt;abstract&gt;</code>, which can be useful when dealing with conditional content.</p> |
| <b>prolog</b>    | <p>A place to put all the metadata for the topic. In general, nothing in this section emits in the topic. This can include:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Author</li><li>• Source</li></ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

- Publisher
- Copyright
- Change History List (technically a specialization, but I'm listing all the prolog things here)
- Critical Dates
- Metadata: keywords, index terms, and 'other meta' such as any name value pair you need.

**body** The container that holds the content of the topic

**related-links** A list of links to other topics of interest (instead of having links in the text).

## Body blocks

These are the elements that can be used as blocks inside of the `<body>`.

Technically, the `<topic>` should not contain specializations. However, the technical content components are usually just included with.

|                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>bodydiv</b>         | Generic container to group content. It can only be used inside of a <code>&lt;body&gt;</code> , so it's mainly for using for specialization.                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>codeblock</b>       | This is a specialization from the programming domain, but it indicates multiple lines of code.                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>div</b>             | A generic container. It can group content with no semantic meaning. In general, avoid using, except for when grouping together a set of blocks you want to reuse instead of dealing with using the fancy <code>conref</code> attributes.                                                                                    |
| <b>dl</b>              | Definition list. You can provide a term and at least one definition. Super useful. Can be displayed as a funky formatted list or as a table. If you add an <code>@id</code> attribute to the <code>&lt;dlentry&gt;</code> element, the <code>&lt;dt&gt;</code> is automatically returned in the <code>&lt;xref&gt;</code> . |
| <b>data</b>            | Basic name value pair for specialization. Does not emit by default. In general, don't use except when you want to support funky processing without a specialization (if you know how to change the formatting).                                                                                                             |
| <b>data-about</b>      | Funky extension thing used with <code>&lt;data&gt;</code> . Used for specializations. Don't use.                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>draft-comment</b>   | One of my favorite elements. The DITA-OT includes a parameter that excludes this element. Enables you to include comments and questions in your writing with less fear that it will show up in the output.                                                                                                                  |
| <b>equation-block</b>  | To define where you're inserting an equation using <code>&lt;mathml&gt;</code> or just an image. Equations often need special formatting or funky fonts, so identifying them can be useful.                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>equation-figure</b> | As <code>&lt;equation-block&gt;</code> , but you can add a <code>&lt;title&gt;</code> .                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>example</b>         | A specialized section that identifies the content as an example.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>fig</b>             | A grouping that identifies a <i>figure</i> . Generally, this is an image with a caption ( <code>&lt;title&gt;</code> ), but could contain text or a codeblock.                                                                                                                                                              |

|                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>foreign</b>          | A special element for identifying things that aren't DITA. Available for specialization. Do not use.                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>hazardstatement</b>  | Fancy specialized Hazard Statements for <a href="https://blog.ansi.org/ansi/ansi-z535-1-2022-safety-colors-standard/">https://blog.ansi.org/ansi/ansi-z535-1-2022-safety-colors-standard/</a> and <a href="https://www.iso.org/standard/51021.html">https://www.iso.org/standard/51021.html</a> . |
| <b>image</b>            | How you link to an image.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>imagemap</b>         | A special image where you can identify zones in the image and associate links with those zones.                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>lines</b>            | A block where white space is preserved, but not necessarily using monospaced font. Often used for addresses or poetry.                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>lq</b>               | Long quote. When you want to identify a quotation that contains multiple paragraphs.                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>mathml</b>           | An element that can contain MATHML, an XML based language for rendering equations. <a href="https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Web/MathML">https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Web/MathML</a>                                                                                          |
| <b>msgblock</b>         | A special block for messages, usually from software.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>note</b>             | A container for short(ish) content you want to emphasize in some way. The default DITA contains several types of notes, including tip, warning, caution, and important.                                                                                                                           |
| <b>object</b>           | An element to reference something not-DITA, such as a video.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>ol</b>               | Ordered list, just like HTML.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>p</b>                | A paragraph, just like HTML.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>parml</b>            | A parameter list. A special list, like <dl>, but for parameters. Not used very often.                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>pre</b>              | Preformatted text, just like HTML.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>required-cleanup</b> | Special element that you should only see during conversion work. If a conversion transform finds a lump of content it can't deal with, wrap it in <required-cleanup> and let a human deal with it.                                                                                                |
| <b>screen</b>           | A specialization to identify content you see on a screen. Very useful when dealing with command line content.                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>section</b>          | A division to group content with an optional title. In general, section titles are not included in the table of contents.                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>simpletable</b>      | A basic table. In DITA 1.3, does not allow row or column spanning. You can only control whether or not separators display.                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>sl</b>               | Simple list. Provides a list without bullets or numbering.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>sort-as</b>          | Special element meant to be used with indexes.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>svg-container</b>    | Special element if you want to include raw SVG code in your topic.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>syntaxdiagram</b>    | Super specialized element for syntax diagrams, used in some programming languages.                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>table</b>            | A CALS based table.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

|                |                                         |
|----------------|-----------------------------------------|
| <b>ul</b>      | Unordered list. Same as HTML.           |
| <b>unknown</b> | Element for specialization. Do not use. |

## Inline elements

There are many block elements that can be used inside of other block elements. For example, you can have an `<image>` or `<ul>` inside of a `<p>`. I am not including those elements again here.

I personally prefer keeping my elements separate. I do not like to have a list inside of a `<p>`, I prefer the list to be after the paragraph. This is my best practice. However other people prefer having the block items inside of paragraphs so that it's easier to reuse them together. That may have made more sense in earlier editions of DITA, but now that you can define conrefs to contain multiple elements, or use a `<div>` to combine them, I prefer to keep things as tidy as possible. Since a lot of formatting is either CSS or XSL-FO based, inheritance matters. A `<ul>` inside of a `<p>` may inherit different margins etc. that just makes troubleshooting formatting issues a pain.

## Generic Elements

|                     |                                                                            |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>b</b>            | Generic bold. Avoid if possible and pick something semantic.               |
| <b>line-through</b> | Formatting to strike through content.                                      |
| <b>markupname</b>   | Generic identifier of some sort of mark up. Meant for specialization.      |
| <b>overline</b>     | Formatting to have a line over the text.                                   |
| <b>sub</b>          | Subscript - Use as needed.                                                 |
| <b>sup</b>          | Superscript - Use as needed.                                               |
| <b>tt</b>           | Generic monospace formatting. Same as HTML. Try to use something semantic. |
| <b>u</b>            | Generic underline formatting. Same as HTML. Try to use something semantic. |

## Semantic Elements

|                         |                                                                                                                                 |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>abbreviated-form</b> | If you use all the special bits of glossaries and the abbreviation domain, use this to identify the abbreviated form of a term. |
| <b>apiname</b>          | For API names                                                                                                                   |
| <b>cite</b>             | To identify a citation.                                                                                                         |
| <b>cmdname</b>          | A command name.                                                                                                                 |
| <b>codeph</b>           | A code phrase                                                                                                                   |
| <b>equation-inline</b>  | Like <code>&lt;equation-block&gt;</code> , but you can have your math inline.                                                   |
| <b>filepath</b>         | For paths when describing things on computers.                                                                                  |
| <b>fn</b>               | Footnote. You enter it right in the text, and the processing will put it at the bottom of the page.                             |
| <b>indexterm</b>        | If you need to have index terms in your content, you can put them where needed, not just in the <code>&lt;prolog&gt;</code>     |



|                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>indextermref</b>      | If you need to do any of that "see also" stuff in your index.                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>keyword</b>           | Identifies an important word. Generally has no formatting, but can help with search results if your processing supports it. Also useful for rendering keys of simple phrases.                       |
| <b>menucascade</b>       | In the software world, you constantly need to identify a set of nested options in menus. Use the <menucascade> to identify and format them for you. For example: Select <b>File</b> > <b>Open</b> . |
| <b>msgnum</b>            | If your system provides codes or IDs for system messages, use this to identify it.                                                                                                                  |
| <b>msgph</b>             | For inline system messages.                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>numcharref object</b> | XML Domain to identify when you reference funky characters by Hex codes. For example # is &#x38f ;.                                                                                                 |
| <b>option</b>            | For software or programming, an option.                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>parameterentity</b>   | XML Domain for parameter entities in schemas.                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>parmname</b>          | For software or programming, a parameter name.                                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>ph</b>                | A phrase. No semantic meaning or formatting, but crazy useful for inserting keys or marking sentences for conditions.                                                                               |
| <b>q</b>                 | An inline quote.                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>synph</b>             | Syntax phrase. Similar to codeph, but slightly different. Sorta like syntax is an algebra equation $a + b = c$ but codeph is a math equation $1 + 2 = 3$ .                                          |
| <b>systemoutput</b>      | Response from a system.                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>term</b>              | Identifies something as a word of importance. You can hook it up with keys to a glossary entry to link to the definition. For example, <a href="#"><i>glossterm</i></a> .                           |
| <b>textentity</b>        | XML domain to identify text entities in schemas.                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>tm</b>                | Use to identify something as a trademark. For example Soon™.                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>uicontrol</b>         | Something in the user interface.                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>userinput</b>         | User input, i.e. something you type in.                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>varname</b>           | Variable name                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>wintitle</b>          | Window title. Can be used for a window, screen, dialog box, etc.                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>xmlatt</b>            | XML domain attribute name                                                                                                                                                                           |
| <b>xmlelement</b>        | XML Domain element name                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>xmlnsname</b>         | XML Domain name space                                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>xmlpi</b>             | XML Domain processing instruction                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>xref</b>              | How you define links.                                                                                                                                                                               |

## Specialization Elements

|                |                                                                             |
|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>boolean</b> | Meant for specialization, an element that can be true or false. Do not use. |
|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|

|              |                                                           |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>state</b> | A name value pair for specialization. Do not use.         |
| <b>text</b>  | Mainly intended as a specialization element. Avoid using. |

## Example Concept Topic

---

An example DITA topic of type concept. This is a shared topic.

This is a topic of type concept.

Concept topics are very similar to topic type topics. A `<concept>` does not have a lot of structure to it.

Concepts are intended for more free-form text, with illustrations, etc.

### Sections

Concepts can have sections. However, once you start a `<section>`, you cannot return to the main body of the `<concept>`.

While sections may seem like just adding a sub-heading, by default, section titles are not included in the table of contents. They can be useful for grouping concepts, highlighting ideas, etc. If you add an `@id` attribute to the `<section>` element, you can link to it, and the title of the section is automatically pulled in by the `<xref>`.

### Section Specialization: Example

An example is just a fancy section. However, it does add the semantic idea of "this is an example" around the contents.

## Example Task Topic

---

A DITA topic of type task. This is a shared topic. Task topics are the most structured.

This is the `<prereq>` where you list the prerequisites for this task. This section is optional.

This is the `<context>` where you can provide a bit of background of things you should know before performing the task.

Some people consider this a "mini concept". If you realize you need a bit of lead in, but not enough for a stand alone topic, use the `<context>` in the task topic instead of a stand alone concept topic. This section is optional.

1. This is a `<step>` in a task topic. It is part of the `<steps>` element. You can use `<steps>` for numbered steps or `<steps-unordered>` for a non-numbered (usually bulleted) steps.
2. These are the heart and soul of task topic.

There are many additional special elements that can be used in a step to provide more information.

3. Both the `<steps>` and `<steps-unordered>` elements are optional.

That's correct, you can have a task with no procedure.

This is the `<result>` which lets you explain what happens after you complete the steps. This element is optional.

This is `<tasktroubleshooting>` where you can provide troubleshooting information for the entire task.

Not to be confused with `<steptroubleshooting>` which can be used for troubleshooting information for specific steps.

This element is optional.

This is an `<example>` you can use to provide an example for the entire task. This is not to be confused with the `<stepxmp>` which can provide a quick example for a specific step.

This element is optional.

This is the `<postreq>` where you describe what to do after completing the procedure.

This element is optional.

That's correct, all of these elements are optional. It is possible to have a valid task topic with only a `<title>` and `<shortdesc>`. However, the order of these main elements is not optional. For example, you cannot switch the order of the `<context>` and `<prereq>` without a specialization.

## Example Reference Topic

---

## Example Troubleshooting

---

### Condition

This is the condition. What is the problem, or at least the symptoms.

### Cause

What is the root cause of the issue.

### Remedy

Who should fix this (Admin, tech, user)

1. This can be a procedure on how to fix the thing.
2. Yes, this is the same step as in a task.

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## Example Glossary

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### **glossterm**

This is the <glossdef> where you can write the definition.